Analysis of the proposed amendment to the citizenship law

An individual view of the September 2026 General Scheme of the Irish Nationality and Citizenship (Amendment) Bill.

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The proposed citizenship changes

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Five years or eight?

Tests that do not exist yet

An income test without a number

A permanent bar for a paperwork offence?

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Conclusion

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The proposed citizenship changes

The Government published the General Scheme of the Irish Nationality and Citizenship (Amendment) Bill on 21 September 2026. It is a proposal, not enacted law. The stated aims are stronger integration, confidence in the system and closer alignment with other EU countries. [1]

What would change

- **Longer residence:** the ordinary route rises from five qualifying years to eight, including two continuous years immediately before applying.
- **Spouses of Irish citizens:** qualifying residence and marriage or civil-partnership duration each rise from three years to five.
- **Language and civics:** applicants must demonstrate a prescribed standard of English, Irish or Irish Sign Language, and knowledge of Irish civics.
- **Income and support:** the ordinary route gains an income condition, restrictions on specified welfare and housing supports, a two-year lookback, and a debt condition. The Scheme does not add this test to the separate spouse route.
- **Conditions during the wait:** ordinary-route applicants must continue meeting residence and specified conditions, including income, until the decision.
- **Fewer years count:** temporary protection and specified unsuccessful EU-rights permissions are excluded. Further temporary permissions can be excluded by regulation. The exclusions also affect the parental residence calculation for children born after commencement.
- **Offences:** specified immigration offences become a separate bar, with no time limit in the proposed wording.
- **Good character:** the condition could no longer be waived in any circumstances, on any route, including for children aged 14 to 17.
- **Revocation:** public policy, public order and national security become additional grounds, none of them defined. Consultation with the Committee of Inquiry's chair is removed when setting procedural regulations.

These changes are set out in Heads 4–10. [2]

What nobody knows yet

Most of what would decide whether a person qualifies is not in the Scheme. It is left to regulations the Minister would make after the Bill is passed:

- the minimum income, and which welfare payments and housing supports would count against an applicant;
- the language level, how it would be tested, what it would cost and who would be exempt;

- the civics syllabus and the pass mark;
- any further temporary permissions that would stop counting as residence;
- the procedure for inquiries into revocation.

There is no start date either. Each part would begin on a day set by ministerial order, and there is no transition rule for people part-way through the five years. Yet in September 2026 the Minister of State said the new residence periods are intended to apply from enactment of the Bill, so even the date that matters is unclear. The Minister of State also confirmed that the test methods and content had not been settled. [1] [2]

For someone four years into their residence, this means they cannot tell whether they will be able to apply next year, in four years' time, or on conditions they have no way of checking yet.

What this means for Ireland

Ireland's economy and public services depend on people recruited from abroad. Nearly half of the nurses and midwives in practice trained outside the EU, and 43.4% of doctors qualified outside Ireland. Non-Irish citizens account for roughly 43% to 65% of the net rise in the number of people in employment since 2021, depending on the base period (47% between the second quarters of 2021 and 2026; method). Many came through the State's own permit system, and they are the people who now become citizens, with their partners and children. [3] [4] [5]

The Scheme would make their route longer and much less predictable. It does not say what problem an eight-year wait would solve, how many people the income test would exclude, or what the changes would do to recruitment and retention in health, social care, IT and pharmaceuticals. [2]

That uncertainty costs Ireland too. Germany, France and the Netherlands ask for five years, and a route to citizenship that nobody can calculate is a weak offer to the nurses, IT specialists and researchers Ireland is trying to attract. [6]

In my view, the Scheme should not go ahead until its case is made with Irish evidence and for Irish needs.

The chapters

1. Who becomes an Irish citizen?
2. Five years or eight?
3. Tests that do not exist yet

4. An income test without a number

5. A permanent bar for a paperwork offence?

6. Wider revocation powers, no stated gap

7. Conclusion

Sources

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Who becomes an Irish citizen?

The Scheme is often discussed as if it were part of migration policy. As a migration tool it is indirect and hard to aim. Ireland already decides, directly, who can come here to work and who can join them. Citizenship comes years after that decision, so changing it mostly affects people who are already living here. To judge what the change would do, the first question is who actually becomes an Irish citizen.

The State already manages migration directly

For workers from outside the EEA, the State chooses which occupations can be filled through an employment permit, sets the minimum salary for each type of permit and can cap numbers in a given job. Family members need their own permission, and the rules set out who counts as family and how much the sponsor must earn. [1] [2] [3]

These rules are changed regularly. In May 2026 the Department of Enterprise revised its occupation lists and quotas to deal with shortages in housing, health and transport. [4] Asylum is a separate system again: whether someone qualifies for protection is decided under protection law, not through permits. [5]

Citizenship comes years later

Nobody can apply for citizenship on arrival. The ordinary route needs five years of reckonable residence, and in 2024 and 2025 a decision took a median of eight months. In practice, people become citizens close to six years after they arrive, by which time they have a job, a tax record and often children in Irish schools. [6] [7]

Raising the requirement to eight years would not change who arrives next year; the permit rules do that. It would change the prospects of people already here, and how Ireland compares with other countries for someone deciding where to build a career. The Scheme does not estimate either effect. [8] The rest of this chapter looks at the people it would reach.

Who became a citizen in 2025

The Department's full-year figures for 2025 show who received a certificate of naturalisation. They count certificates issued, not new arrivals or applications received that year. [9]

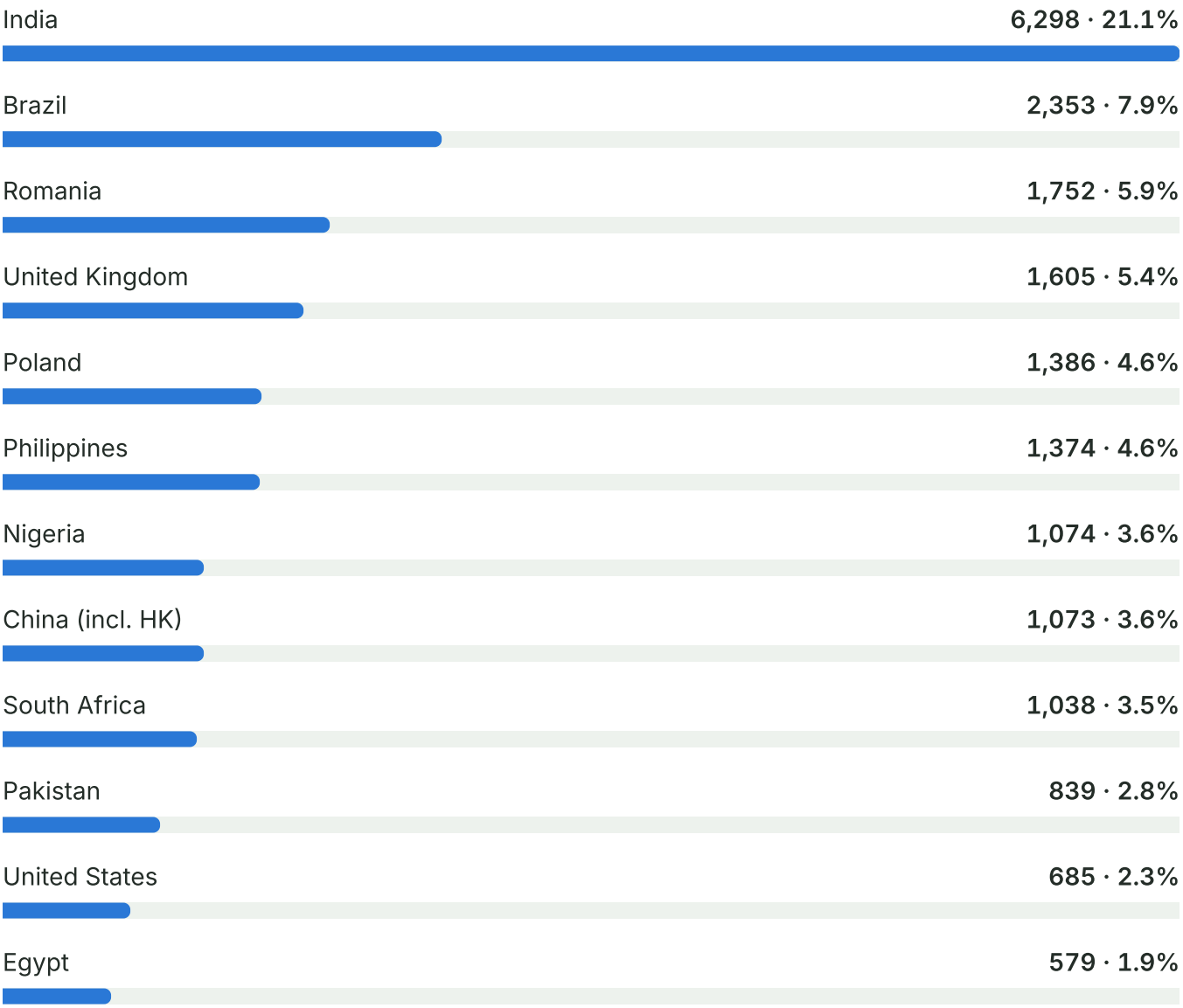
Certificates issued in 2025, by application route

Route	Certificates	Share
Adults, ordinary residence route	19,329	64.6%
Spouses and civil partners of Irish citizens (“S15 residency”)	2,929	9.8%
People with international protection (refugees, subsidiary protection)	712	2.4%
Children (minors)	6,949	23.2%
Total	29,919	100%

Adults on the ordinary residence route received 64.6% of certificates. Children received 23.2%, and spouses and civil partners of Irish citizens (the Department’s “S15 residency” category) 9.8%. So one certificate in three went to a child or a partner. People with international protection, meaning refugees and people with subsidiary protection, received 2.4%. [10]

Where new citizens come from

Certificates issued in 2025: the 12 largest nationalities (of 29,919 in total)



Show the data as a table

Certificates issued in 2025, by nationality

Nationality	Certificates	Share
India	6,298	21.1%
Brazil	2,353	7.9%
Romania	1,752	5.9%
United Kingdom	1,605	5.4%
Poland	1,386	4.6%
Philippines	1,374	4.6%
Nigeria	1,074	3.6%
China (incl. HK)	1,073	3.6%
South Africa	1,038	3.5%
Pakistan	839	2.8%
United States	685	2.3%
Egypt	579	1.9%

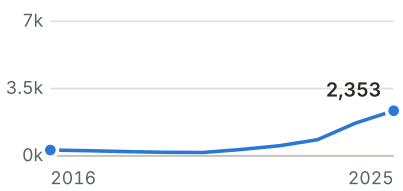
India is by far the largest nationality, with 6,298 certificates in 2025. That is 21.1% of the total, up from 10.3% in 2016. Brazil, the Philippines, Nigeria, China, South Africa and Pakistan follow; their citizens generally need an employment permit to work in Ireland. Romania, the United Kingdom and Poland are also in the top ten, and their citizens can live and work here without one. [11]

Certificates per year, 2016–2025: the eight largest nationalities in 2025, on the same scale

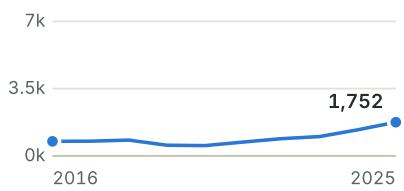
India



Brazil



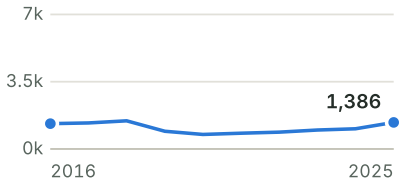
Romania



United Kingdom



Poland



Philippines



Nigeria



China (incl. HK)



Show the data as a table

Certificates per year, by nationality

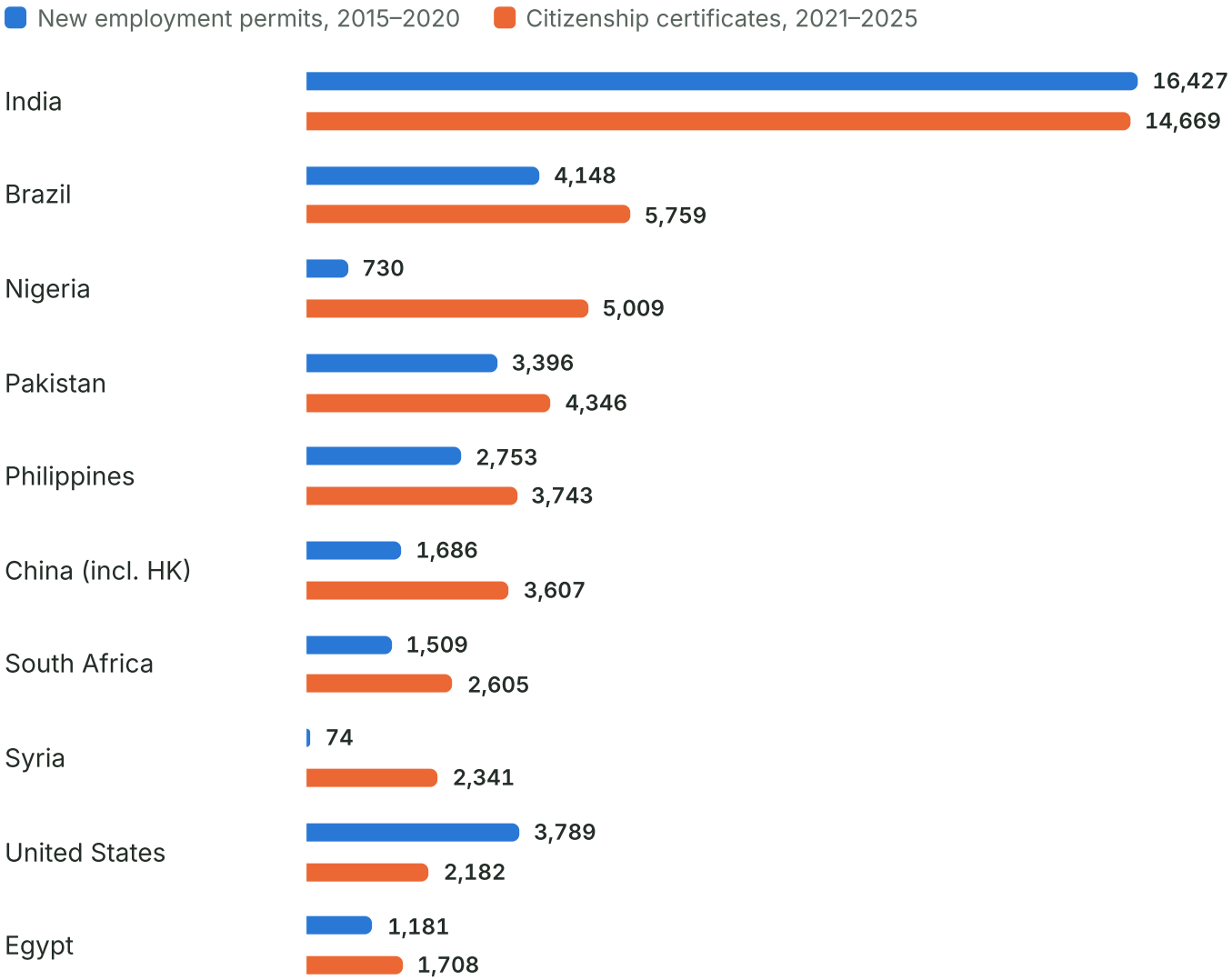
Nationality	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
India	1,026	665	628	513	465	746	1,177	2,502	3,946	6,298
Brazil	302	263	218	187	179	333	523	842	1,708	2,353
Romania	756	763	819	551	538	719	893	1,007	1,355	1,752
United Kingdom	98	525	684	663	941	1,186	1,255	1,004	1,539	1,605
Poland	1,321	1,355	1,463	925	756	818	874	990	1,047	1,386
Philippines	727	360	318	191	157	216	333	698	1,122	1,374
Nigeria	770	506	478	303	227	743	784	1,173	1,235	1,074
China (incl. HK)	302	223	234	159	128	292	389	860	993	1,073

Certificates rose from 9,766 in 2021 to 29,919 in 2025, and India alone accounts for 27.5% of that increase. Most of the growth comes from the countries Ireland recruited from through the permit system in the late 2010s. Poland, by contrast, is close to where it was in 2016. [11]

Most came to work

The usual path for a worker from outside the EU is an employment permit first and citizenship at least five years later. The nationality figures follow that pattern. Eight of the ten non-EU nationalities with the most first-time permits in 2015–2020 are also among the ten with the most new citizens in 2021–2025. [12] [11]

The ten non-EU nationalities with the most certificates in 2021–2025, against first-time employment permits five years earlier



Show the data as a table

First-time employment permits 2015–2020 and certificates 2021–2025

Nationality	New employment permits, 2015–2020	Citizenship certificates, 2021–2025
India	16,427	14,669
Brazil	4,148	5,759
Nigeria	730	5,009
Pakistan	3,396	4,346
Philippines	2,753	3,743
China (incl. HK)	1,686	3,607
South Africa	1,509	2,605
Syria	74	2,341
United States	3,789	2,182
Egypt	1,181	1,708

India had 16,427 first-time permits in 2015–2020 and 14,669 certificates in 2021–2025. For Brazil, Pakistan, the Philippines and South Africa, certificates exceed the earlier permits, partly because partners and children naturalise as well. Nigeria and Syria look different: few of their citizens came on permits, and Syrian certificates are more likely to reflect international protection. The two datasets cannot be linked person by person, so the chart compares nationalities, not individuals. [12]

The permits themselves show what kind of work these are. Critical Skills permits are for highly skilled occupations in short supply; General permits cover other jobs the State has agreed can be filled from abroad. In 2024 the two together made up 36,646 of 39,398 permits (93.0%), counting renewals. [13] [2]

Employment permits issued in 2024, including renewals

Sector	Critical Skills	General	Total permits
Health & social work	5,917	6,556	12,507
Information & communication	4,932	1,040	6,787
Agriculture, forestry & fishing	28	3,536	3,625
Accommodation & food services	97	3,219	3,359
Chemicals & pharmaceuticals	451	35	829
Medical devices	146	31	289
Computers, electronics & optical	164	13	570
Other sectors	5,433	5,048	11,432
Total	17,168	19,478	39,398

Health and social work is the largest sector by a wide margin and uses both routes. IT relies mostly on Critical Skills permits, while agriculture and hospitality rely mainly on General permits. Pharmaceutical, medical-device and electronics manufacturers recruit through the system too. [13]

The health service depends on them

5,031 Critical Skills permits in 2024 went to nurses, more than twice the 2,247 issued to programmers and software developers. [14] The professional registers show the same dependence.

Nurses and midwives by qualification location, 1 June 2025

Educated in	Registered	Practising	Patient-facing
Irish educated	45,640	41,938	37,041
Other EU educated	2,851	2,578	2,393
Non-EU educated	43,894	42,432	39,760
Total	92,385	86,948	79,194

On NMBI's register at 1 June 2025, nurses and midwives educated outside the EU made up 48.8% of those in practice and 50.2% of those in patient-facing roles. The flow of new staff is even more lopsided: of the 7,120 people who registered for the first time between June 2023 and May 2024, 5,426 qualified outside the EU. [15] [16]

Doctors follow the same pattern. The Medical Council's 2025 report, published on 2 September 2026, found that 43.4% of the 22,257 clinically active doctors took their primary medical qualification outside Ireland: 13.9% in the EU or UK and 29.5% elsewhere, up from 23.3% in 2022. These figures describe where people trained, not their nationality. [17]

What they contribute

Between the second quarters of 2021 and 2026, the number of people in employment in Ireland rose by 457,100, and 215,900 of that net rise, or 47.2%, was among non-Irish citizens. Their share of all employment rose from 16.6% to 21.5%. The percentage depends on the base period: 42.9% from Q1 2021 to Q1 2026, about 52% from the 2021 annual average and about 65% from a Q4 2021 base. Early 2021 was depressed by COVID-19 restrictions, which flatters growth measured from then. The CSO does not publish this percentage; it is calculated here (method). People who have already naturalised count as Irish in these figures, so they understate the contribution of migrants. [18]

Employment rates, ages 20–64, 2024

Area	Non-EU citizens	National citizens	Gap
Ireland	77.4%	79.5%	2.1 points
EU	64.3%	76.7%	12.4 points

Among people aged 20–64, the employment rate of non-EU citizens in Ireland is 2.1 points below that of Irish citizens. Across the EU the gap is 12.4 points, and Ireland's non-EU employment rate is 13.1 points above the EU average. [19] They are also well qualified: in Q2 2024, 67% of non-Irish residents aged 25–64 had a third-level qualification, compared with 53% of Irish residents. [20]

The latest review of the fiscal evidence for Ireland, published by the ESRI in June 2026, sums it up in one sentence: "immigrants in Ireland make a positive fiscal contribution, fully financing their share of public services." [21]

Net contribution to the public finances in Ireland, OECD estimate, average of 2006–2018

Measure	Born abroad	Born in Ireland
Taxes paid, less benefits and services received	+1.57%	+2.87%
… and a share of police, transport, water and similar services	+0.62%	−2%
… and a share of defence, debt interest and all other public spending	−0.21%	−6.12%
Paid in for every €1 received (individual items)	€1.52	€1.14

These OECD figures average 2006–2018. On the individual measure, immigrants paid in €1.52 for every euro they received in benefits and services, compared with €1.14 for people born in Ireland. They stayed in credit once a share of police, transport and other shared services was charged to them. People born in Ireland did not, and Ireland was the only country in the study where that happened. Only when defence, debt interest and all other public spending is divided per head does everyone come out behind, and the Irish-born more so. The ESRI attributes these negative figures to the deficits that followed 2008; the period does not include the budget surpluses of recent years. [19]

Annual tax and social insurance less benefits per person: 2015–2019 estimate for Ireland

Population	Net contribution
Native-born	€940
Non-EU migrants	€1,047
Intra-EU migrants	€1,718

A separate EU estimate for 2015–2019 found a positive net contribution for every group, and a larger one for non-EU migrants than for people born in Ireland. International studies reviewed in the same report find that people who come through work routes, and higher-skilled migrants in particular, have the most positive fiscal impact. [19]

Use of unemployment payments points the same way. Between 2014 and 2024, 12% of people born in Asia received one, compared with 16% of people born in Ireland; the rate was higher, at 21%, for people born in the eastern EU and in Africa. [22] Nor is citizenship handed out quickly. The ESRI estimates that about 30% of non-EEA migrants who arrived since 2005 had become Irish citizens, with an annual acquisition rate of around 4%. [23]

What the evidence shows

Most people who become Irish citizens came here to work. Many arrived on employment permits as nurses, care workers, doctors and IT specialists, in jobs the State itself chose to recruit for abroad. Others came from the EU or the UK and needed no permit. They lived and worked here for five years, applied, and waited most of another year for a decision. Their partners and children applied with them: one certificate in three in 2025 went to a spouse, civil partner or child.

They are, in large part, the skilled professionals Ireland competes with other countries to attract. They work at close to the same rate as Irish citizens, they are more likely to hold a third-level qualification, and on the best available estimates they pay more into the public finances than they take out.

These are the people the Scheme would affect. It does not touch the permit and visa rules that decide who comes to Ireland. It lengthens and complicates the route for people who are already working and settling here, and it changes the offer Ireland makes to the people it will need to recruit in future, many of them for the health service. The Government has not estimated what that would cost in recruitment or retention. [8]

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Five years or eight?

The Scheme raises the residence needed for ordinary naturalisation from five years to eight, and the last two of those years must be continuous. For most future applicants it is the change they will feel first. [1]

Five years is common in the EU

The EU has no common rule. Seven member states let people apply after five years, counting any time needed first to obtain permanent residence: Belgium, France, Germany, Ireland (under the current rule), Luxembourg, Malta and the Netherlands. [2] How each country was checked.

The Government's announcement pointed to countries that require seven to ten years, among them Austria, Italy and Spain. It did not mention the seven member states that require five. [3]

Why eight?

The Scheme gives one reason. The longer period is meant to "establish a proportionate timeline that encourages steady economic and social integration before naturalisation". [1]

It does not say why eight years is proportionate and five is not, which Irish problem the extra three years would solve, or how the number reflects Ireland's own circumstances: a labour market that recruits abroad, a health service that depends on overseas-trained staff, and a national strategy to attract researchers. The people who naturalise here are, as the previous chapter shows, mostly already working and settled.

Uncertainty for people already here

The change falls on people who came under the current rules and planned their lives around them. Many are nurses, carers, doctors and IT specialists, recruited through a permit system that is still running: the State issued 31,044 employment permits in 2025, including renewals. [4] Ireland keeps inviting people to come and settle while telling them that the route to citizenship may become three years longer.

The Scheme has no transition rule for the residence period, and the start date will be set by ministerial order. Someone four and a half years into a five-year wait could find they need another three and a half, without knowing when the change takes effect. [1] The Government's own statements add to the doubt. In a parliamentary answer the Minister of State said the new residence periods are "intended to apply from enactment of the new Bill", and that people can apply under the current rules "only … until the new Bill is enacted", while the Scheme ties the start to a later commencement order. Applicants cannot tell which date will count. [10] For many families, citizenship is the point at which they stop renewing immigration permissions and can

plan for the long term. Moving that point, with no date and no protection for people part-way through, adds real stress to people who are working in Ireland and paying tax here.

Students and researchers would wait twelve years

Time on a student permission (Stamp 2) does not count as reckonable residence now, and would not count under the Scheme. [5] [6] A PhD student who spends four years on Stamp 2 and then takes a job in Ireland still has to build up the full residence period afterwards: nine years in total under the current rule, twelve under the proposal.

Until then, non-EU researchers travel on their original passports. Ireland is outside the Schengen area, and an Irish residence permission does not open it, so many need a separate Schengen visa for each conference, research visit or internship. [7] The European Commission itself acknowledges "long waiting times for Schengen visa appointments" in some places. [8] When an appointment cannot be found in time, the researcher misses the event, and the Irish university loses the chance to present its work.

Ireland's own talent strategy, Global Citizens 2030, sets out to attract international researchers and PhD students. [9] Three more years before they can apply for citizenship works against that aim.

Families in Northern Ireland

Irish citizenship is an all-island status. The Bar of Ireland, in its October 2026 submission, says the Scheme appears to have been drafted mainly with people living in the State in mind, and that Irish citizens in Northern Ireland and their families were given insufficient consideration. [11]

The spouse route counts residence "in the island of Ireland", and Head 6 keeps that wording while raising the periods. It is the main way Irish citizens in Northern Ireland pass citizenship on to a spouse or civil partner. Since Brexit it is also, in practice, the main way such a family can share EU citizenship, because a non-EU spouse who naturalises as British does not become an EU citizen. Yet the explanatory note to Head 6 describes its purpose as increasing the time a spouse "should be residing in the state". The Bar reads this as a sign that families in Northern Ireland were not in contemplation, and asks that the Bill confirm that residence there still counts. [5] [1] [11]

The rules on which residence does not count are written for the State. For citizenship at birth, section 6B(5) already excludes some residence in Northern Ireland by reference to section 6B(4). Because Head 4 replaces section 6B(4), it would widen those exclusions in Northern Ireland too, including any further permissions the Minister prescribes under Head 9. Neither Head mentions this. For the spouse route there would be no statutory rules on residence in

Northern Ireland at all, so its treatment would rest on Department policy under an absolute discretion, with less transparency than for applicants in the State. [5] [11]

Unmarried partners

An unmarried partner in a durable relationship with an Irish citizen is worse placed still. In the State, such a partner can hold a permission based on the relationship and build up residence on the ordinary route. In Northern Ireland they cannot: the ordinary route counts only residence "in the State", and the partner route is limited to spouses and civil partners. However long the relationship, residence in Northern Ireland counts for nothing. [5] [11]

The Bar points out that the same partner could qualify for British citizenship through residence in Northern Ireland, so a British citizen there can share citizenship with a partner and an Irish citizen living in the same place cannot. The problem predates the Scheme, but by lengthening the ordinary route Head 5 makes it worse. The Bar proposes that recognised partners of Irish citizens be allowed to count residence anywhere on the island, proved either through recognition under UK immigration law or to the standard the Department already applies to partners in the State. [11]

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Tests that do not exist yet

Asking applicants to show some English or Irish, and a basic knowledge of how the State works, is a reasonable idea in itself. The difficulty is that the Scheme makes both tests a condition of citizenship before there is a test to sit. [1]

Nothing about the tests has been decided

In September 2026 the Minister of State confirmed that the language standard, the testing method and the exemptions were still undecided. The civics content and pass mark were not settled either. All of this is left to regulations made after the Bill is passed. [2]

The Scheme allows the language test in English, Irish or Irish Sign Language and permits waivers. It says nothing about fees, where tests would be held, preparation material, how the Irish and Irish Sign Language options would be assessed, or when the service would start. [1]

The scale of the task

Ireland received 41,511 naturalisation applications in 2025. At two tests per person, with 20% extra sittings for retakes, that is about 99,627 sittings a year. [3]

Estimated centres, assuming 200 operating days per year

Seats per room	Sessions per day	Sittings per year / centre	Centres needed
10	2	4,000	25
20	2	8,000	13
20	4	16,000	7

This is a planning estimate: 200 operating days a year and one room per centre. The middle case needs 13 centres; if 30% of applicants were exempt from both tests, it would need nine. The application total includes children, some of whom may be exempt, so the real figure depends on exemption rules that do not exist yet. Calculation and assumptions.

Eligibility would depend on a test place

If the tests begin before the service can cope, people who meet every other condition would be waiting for an appointment rather than for a decision on their case. The Scheme contains no timetable or capacity commitment that rules this out. [1]

Tests written for the State

The two civics conditions are not worded the same way. The ordinary route asks for “a knowledge and understanding of Irish civics [civics, society and politics]”; the spouse route asks only for “an understanding of Irish civics”. The Bar of Ireland, in its October 2026 submission, notes that it is unclear whether spouses would sit the same test. [1] [4]

Spouses can qualify through residence anywhere on the island. Nothing in the Scheme says whether a civics test would cover Northern Ireland, the Good Friday Agreement institutions or North–South arrangements, whether it could be taken in Northern Ireland, or whether language and knowledge tests already passed for UK immigration purposes would count. The language options are English, Irish and Irish Sign Language, although British Sign Language is the main sign language of Deaf people in Northern Ireland and Ulster-Scots is a recognised minority language there. The waiver power is aimed at vulnerable applicants, not at people living in Northern Ireland. [1] [4]

The Bar adds a point of principle. Under the Good Friday Agreement, people in Northern Ireland may identify as Irish, British or both, and an Irish citizen there need not share a State-centred idea of Irishness. A spouse’s eligibility should not depend on knowing one. It also warns that knowledge-based civic tests have operated elsewhere as barriers to participation. It proposes that any civics test be objective and limited to what is relevant to citizenship on the island, and that the content and standard of both tests be set by regulations approved by each House of the Oireachtas, after consulting North–South bodies. [4]

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An income test without a number

The Scheme adds a self-sufficiency test to the ordinary route but leaves the income figure, and the list of payments that would count against an applicant, to later regulations. Nobody can yet work out whether they would pass.

What the proposed test covers

Head 5 requires a prescribed minimum income, restrictions on prescribed welfare and housing supports, and no Revenue or social-welfare debt or outstanding court fine. Income and support conditions continue during processing. A two-year support lookback applies, with a discretionary exception for receipt totalling no more than six months. Head 7 leaves the income amount and payment lists to regulations. [1]

A national average is not a household budget

Annual employment earnings, 2024; employments active at least 50 weeks

Measure	Annual earnings
Mean, all	€56,356
Median, all	€44,816
Median, women	€40,424
Median, men	€48,897

The mean was 25.8% above the median. A threshold set at the mean would sit above the earnings of at least half the employments in this dataset. The Scheme does not specify a mean-based threshold; the comparison shows why the choice of measure matters. [2] [1]

Ordinary life events

- Maternity or parental leave can reduce earnings while employment continues.
- Illness or disability can make income support necessary.
- Unpaid carers contribute time that does not appear in a payslip.
- Redundancy can interrupt earnings after years of work and contributions.

Census 2022 counted 299,128 unpaid carers; 61% were women. This is a substantial form of contribution that an individual salary test does not measure. [3]

Who counts as a “burden”

Head 5 would require an applicant to have “sufficient resources for himself or herself not to become an unreasonable burden on the State”. [1] The people most likely to fall below an income line at a given moment are not idle. They are carers looking after a relative, people with a disability, and mothers on maternity leave or working part-time while their children are small. Women are 61% of unpaid carers, and women’s median earnings are about €8,500 a year below men’s. [3] [2] A test written in these terms would fall hardest on them, so in practice it discriminates against carers, disabled people and mothers.

The premise is also weak. The latest review of the evidence, published by the ESRI in June 2026, reports that in 2015–2019 non-EU migrants in Ireland paid in a net €1,047 a year per person in taxes and social insurance after benefits, more than people born in Ireland (€940). Ireland was one of only eight EU countries where non-EU migrants contributed more than natives. [4]

The wording itself is the problem. It asks whether a person, after years of living, working and paying tax here, is a cost to the State. Caring for a family member, having a disability or having a child are ordinary parts of life. Treating them as grounds to suspect someone of being a “burden” judges people by their bank balance rather than by their place in Irish society, and that is inhumane.

Nothing in the Scheme protects these situations. The list of disqualifying payments could include maternity, illness, disability or carer’s payments, and whether it will is unknown. The two-year lookback would reach back to a time before applicants could have known the rules. Because the income condition continues until a decision, losing a job while waiting could end an application. [1]

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A permanent bar for a paperwork offence?

The proposed Schedule is not confined to identity fraud or illegal entry. It also reaches administrative duties. Under Heads 5 and 6, committing a listed offence would create a separate citizenship bar with no time limit in the wording. [1]

Three concrete examples

Existing duties included through Schedule 1

Duty	Legal provision
Notify a new home address within 48 hours if it was not notified in advance.	Immigration Act 2004, sections 9(2)(c) and 9(8). [2]
Notify the current address when absent from the registered residence for more than one month.	Sections 9(2)(d) and 9(8). [2]
Produce a passport or equivalent document and, where registered, a registration certificate on a lawful demand.	Section 12. A reasonable-cause defence applies. [3]

These examples concern people to whom the duties apply. They are not a claim that every late update or missing document automatically proves an offence. They show the range of conduct covered by the proposed bar.

Good character does not demand perfection

In Hussain v Minister for Justice [2011] IEHC 171, paragraph 15, Hogan J. said the standard was “reasonable standards of civic responsibility as gauged by reference to contemporary values”. Applicants could not be held to behaviour unrealistically higher than that expected of Irish people. [4]

The judgment also permits consideration of serious wrongdoing without a conviction, provided fair procedures are followed. The issue is proper evidence and an individual assessment, not an entitlement to ignore misconduct. [4]

No discretion on good character, even for children

Head 8 would add a new subsection (1B) to section 16: the good-character condition in sections 15(1)(b), 15A(1)(b) and 15B(1)(b) “cannot be waived in any circumstances”. That covers the ordinary route, spouses and civil partners of Irish citizens, and minors born in the State. [1]

Under section 15B, the condition does not apply to a child under 14 unless the child is charged with or convicted of murder, manslaughter, rape or aggravated sexual assault. From 14 it does apply, but section 15B(4) lets the Minister waive it where the particular circumstances of the minor make that appropriate. Head 8 would take that power away. Section 16 also lets the Minister dispense with section 15 conditions for some applicants: people of Irish descent or associations, the minor children of naturalised citizens, refugees and stateless people. As drafted, the new subsection would also stop good character being dispensed with on those routes. The Scheme does not say how this applies to younger children on them. [5] [1]

The explanatory note gives one reason: “to ensure consistency and to reflect the policy position that all applicants must be of good character”. It refers only to section 15(1)(b). It does not mention children, the existing waiver for those aged 14 to 17, or any case in which that waiver was misused. [1]

The Irish Human Rights and Equality Commission, in its October 2026 submission on the Scheme, says it should be considered whether this is compliant with the rights of the child. The Commission has previously connected naturalisation to the State’s duties under Article 7 of the UN Convention on the Rights of the Child, which includes the right to acquire a nationality. [6]

The change does not raise the standard expected of a teenager; it removes the room to apply it with judgment. Where a 15- or 16-year-old falls short, the Minister could no longer weigh the child’s age, maturity, family situation or the time since an incident, which is what section 15B(4) allows now. A refusal could leave a child with a different status from parents and siblings who become citizens. Minors received 6,949 certificates in 2025, but the published figures do not show how many were 14 or older, or how many needed a waiver. [5] [7]

The Bar of Ireland, in its October 2026 submission, makes the same point for all applicants, adults included: in light of the principle of proportionality, the Minister should keep a discretion to waive good character in exceptional circumstances. [8]

The bar is not ordered by seriousness

A scheduled registration offence receives an express bar with no expiry, while a non-scheduled offence such as ordinary theft remains subject to the good-character assessment. That does not guarantee citizenship after theft; it shows that the Schedule’s treatment is not simply ordered by seriousness. [1] [5]

The Scheme says nothing about how an offence would be proved, how far back it can reach, or how an old breach could be reviewed. As written, an address change notified late and later corrected would carry the same permanent consequence as deliberate fraud. [1]

The Bar of Ireland reaches the same conclusion. It calls the offence condition categorical: it makes no exception for the seriousness or age of the offence, the applicant’s circumstances, the

relevance of the conduct to the application, or how long ago it was committed. It notes that rules of this kind elsewhere have led to refusals for long-term residents in good standing, giving the example of a traffic offence committed some 20 years earlier, and concludes that the framing "displays a lack of proportionality". [8]

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Wider revocation powers, no stated gap

Losing citizenship can end a person's right to live in Ireland and affects their whole family. The revocation procedure was rebuilt only recently, and the Scheme would widen it again.

What the figures show

Minister's answer, 16 September 2026

Measure	Number
Revocations in the preceding ten years	8
Of those, since the revised procedure began on 7 April 2025	2
Fraud-related grounds	7
Loyalty/residence grounds	1

The Department already reviews terrorism, fraud, organised crime and serious-crime cases for possible revocation. Existing grounds include fraud and an overt act showing failure of loyalty to the State. [1] [2]

What Head 10 adds

The Scheme adds public policy, public order and national security as grounds. It cites a changed security environment, but gives no concrete case showing why existing grounds are insufficient. Eight cases alone cannot establish that a new power is unnecessary; the missing evidence is the specific legal gap. [3]

It also removes consultation with the chairperson of the Committee of Inquiry, a retired judge, when the Minister makes procedural regulations. This is not a requirement to consult the chair before initiating an individual case. Notice, representations and the right to request an inquiry remain. The explanatory note says the change creates "an enduring regulatory framework so that new regulations are not required each time this process is utilised". [3] [2]

The Commission's concerns, in 2024 and now

The 2024 changes followed a Supreme Court finding against the old procedure. In July 2024, the Irish Human Rights and Equality Commission called for more scrutiny. Its concerns included the initiation threshold, the inquiry's independence and restrictions when national-security material is involved. That was its assessment of the 2024 amendments. [1] [4]

In its October 2026 submission on this Scheme, the Commission returns to the same points. It notes that Head 10 is the only part of the Scheme that concerns people who are already Irish citizens, and it raises two issues: the new ground, and the removal of the chair's role in setting the inquiry's procedures. [5]

A security ground, and no duty to give reasons

National security is not a ground for revocation today. Since the 2024 amendments it matters only at a later stage: the Minister need not give reasons for a revocation where giving them would be contrary to the interests of national security. [2] [5]

Head 10 would join the two. As the Commission points out, the Minister could revoke citizenship on grounds of public policy, public order or national security and, where they consider it in the interests of national security, not explain the decision. In 2024 the Commission had already warned that a person who is not told the reasons cannot answer the case against them, and that the Committee of Inquiry has no right to see the national-security evidence behind the Minister's decision. It relies on AP v Minister for Justice [2019] IESC 47, in which the Supreme Court recognised a right to know the reason for a decision even in national-security cases, limited only to the extent needed to protect security. [5]

Three new terms, no definitions

The Scheme does not define public policy, public order or national security. The explanatory note explains only national security: it cites "a changed EU and international security landscape" and says "broad wording better lends itself to the variety of circumstances (albeit relatively rare)". It gives no reason for adding public policy or public order. [3]

The Commission links this to legal certainty: a law must be clear, precise and foreseeable enough for a person to regulate their conduct by it. It asks whether terms that "could encompass a vast array of conduct and scenarios" meet that test, citing the Venice Commission's Rule of Law Checklist. [5]

The Commission also points to limits outside Irish law. For someone whose only EU nationality is Irish, revocation also ends EU citizenship, so EU law requires the decision to be proportionate and to respect the Charter of Fundamental Rights, as the Court of Justice held in Rottmann (C-135/08) and Tjebbes (C-221/17). Under Article 8 of the European Convention on Human Rights, an arbitrary or disproportionate loss of citizenship can interfere with private life. [5]

The inquiry loses its say on procedure

In Damache v Minister for Justice [2020] IESC 63, the Supreme Court found that the old revocation process lacked minimum procedural safeguards, including an independent and

impartial decision-maker. The Committee of Inquiry, chaired by a retired judge, is the State's response to that judgment. [5] [1]

The Commission's view is that the Minister, not the Committee, already has the final word on the inquiry's procedures, including when oral hearings are held. Consultation with the chair is one of the few checks on how those procedures are set, and Head 10 would remove it. The Commission says it is not clear that this meets Damache's requirement of fair procedures and adequate safeguards, that it raises further questions about the Committee's independence, and that it will inevitably lead to litigation. [5]

Who has to prove what

The procedure for the new ground would be the one introduced in April 2025. The Minister sends a notice of intention to revoke, and the person has 28 days to make representations. If the Minister proceeds, the person has 14 days to request a Committee of Inquiry, which can affirm the decision or set it aside. [1]

The Scheme keeps that procedure but attaches no test to the new ground. As the Bar of Ireland notes in its October 2026 submission, it does not say how the Minister is to assess the seriousness of the conduct, its connection to public policy, public order or national security, or the effect of revocation on the person. The Bar argues that the deliberately broad drafting minimises statutory constraints and shifts "the burden of proof heavily onto the citizen", and that it cedes excessive discretion to the Minister rather than the Oireachtas. [6] [6]

The Scheme does not change the burden of proof in its wording; the shift the Bar describes is practical. Someone answering a notice would have to show why revocation is not "in the interests of public policy, public order or national security" without a definition of those terms. Where reasons are withheld on national-security grounds, they may not know the case they have to answer. Representations and an inquiry protect a person only if there is a standard to argue against. [3] [6]

What is still missing

No case has been published that the existing grounds, fraud and an overt act of disloyalty, could not deal with. The Department can reply that security cases are rarely made public. That makes a precise definition more important, not less: without one, nobody outside the Department can tell what conduct the new ground is meant to reach. [3]

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Conclusion

Each chapter looks at one part of the Scheme. Read together, they describe a proposal that falls on people Ireland has already chosen to recruit, and leaves them unable to plan.

The core finding of this analysis is that the proposed changes would affect Ireland negatively. They would make citizenship slower and less certain for the nurses, doctors, carers, engineers and researchers the country depends on and competes for, without identifying a problem that the changes would solve.

Who carries the change

Most people who become Irish citizens came here to work: nurses, care workers, doctors and IT specialists, many on employment permits for jobs the State listed as hard to fill. In 2025 one certificate in three went to a child or to the spouse or civil partner of an Irish citizen. These are settled families, not new arrivals. [1] [2]

They are also people Ireland depends on. Nearly half of the nurses and midwives in practice trained outside the EU, and non-Irish citizens account for roughly 43% to 65% of the net rise in the number of people in employment since 2021, depending on the base period (method). On the best available estimates, immigrants in Ireland pay more into the public finances than they take out. [3] [4] [5]

Too much is left open

The Scheme fixes the new residence periods but leaves most of what decides eligibility to regulations that do not yet exist: the income figure, the welfare payments and housing supports that would count against an applicant, the language level, the civics syllabus, the pass marks, the exemptions and any further permissions that would stop counting as residence. The Minister of State confirmed in September 2026 that the tests had not been designed. [6] [7]

No start date is set; each part would begin on a day chosen by ministerial order, although the Minister of State has said the residence changes are intended to apply from enactment. [7] The Scheme gives no reason for eight years rather than five, publishes no estimate of how many people the income test would exclude, and contains no assessment of the effect on recruitment or retention. [6]

Plans already made

A person who began uninterrupted qualifying residence in January 2022 reaches five years in January 2027 and eight in January 2030. If the new rule applies before they can submit, their application moves three years later, before processing even begins. The Scheme protects

applications already lodged from its new residence exclusions, but nobody who is still working towards eligibility. [8] [6]

The same gap runs through the other conditions. The income lookback reaches back two years into a period when the rules were unknown, and the income and support conditions continue until a decision, so a job loss or illness while waiting could end an application. [6]

Families and children

Children received 6,949 certificates in 2025. For children born after the change, Head 4 would alter which parental residence counts towards citizenship at birth, including excluding time on temporary protection and on any further permissions the Minister excludes by regulation. [1] [6]

Head 8 would also end the Minister's power to waive the good-character condition for children aged 14 to 17, a power that exists so a child's particular circumstances can be taken into account. The Scheme gives no reason specific to children (chapter 5). [6] [8]

Families in Northern Ireland receive little attention in the Scheme. The spouse route counts residence anywhere on the island, but its explanatory note speaks of residence in the State, and the tests are framed around the State. An unmarried partner of an Irish citizen in Northern Ireland still has no way to count residence at all, and the longer ordinary route makes that worse (chapter 2). [6] [9]

What Ireland stands to lose

Ireland competes for skilled workers and researchers with other countries. Germany, France, the Netherlands and Belgium ask for five years. A PhD graduate who stays in Ireland would wait twelve years under the proposal, and until then may need a Schengen visa for each conference abroad. [10] [11] [12]

The Government's own talent strategy aims to attract international researchers and PhD students. [13] The Scheme pulls the other way, with a longer route, conditions nobody can yet check and no date. That is the main cost of the proposal as published: a route to citizenship that the people Ireland most wants to keep can no longer plan around.

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12. Citizens Information · The Schengen Area (https://www.citizensinformation.ie/en/government-in-ireland/european-government/european-union/schengen-area/) Research note
13. Government · Global Citizens 2030 talent and innovation strategy (https://www.gov.ie/en/department-of-further-and-higher-education-research-innovation-and-science/publications/global-citizens-2030-irelands-talent-and-innovation-strategy/) Research note

Sources and calculations

Each numbered reference links to the original publisher. The notes below identify what each dataset measures and show how the calculations can be reproduced. Research checked on 26 September 2026.

Data definitions and calculations

Citizenship recipients and processing times

The route table counts certificates issued in 2025, not arrivals or applications. Shares use 29,919 as the denominator. The Department's "S15 residency" category is the route for spouses and civil partners of Irish citizens; "Granted International Protection" covers refugees and people with subsidiary protection. Children (23.2%) and spouses or civil partners (9.8%) together make up 33.0% of certificates. The source does not link recipients to earlier employment permits.

The January 2026 certificate table gives 29,919 for 2025; a later answer gives 29,300 certificates conferred. The site uses the first series consistently. The 2023 total of 18,265 comes from the original table because a suppressed cell prevents a complete sum of route figures. Applications and grants in the same year are not a matched group and cannot yield an approval rate. Processing figures are medians, not minimum waiting periods. [1] [2] [3]

Employment permits

The sector table includes renewals and all permit types. It counts permits, not unique workers, citizenship recipients or HSE hires. Critical Skills and General permits total 17,168 + 19,478 = 36,646; dividing by 39,398 gives 93.0%.

The official sector extract sums to 39,398, eight more than the annual series total of 39,390. The table and its shares consistently use the sector extract. [4] [5]

EU residence requirements

The residence chapter counts the **total** residence needed before an ordinary application. Where a country requires permanent residence for its naturalisation period, the years needed to obtain permanent residence are added. The starting point is Figure 2 of the European Parliament brief (GLOBALCIT data with 2025 updates); each country was rechecked in September 2026.

Fifteen countries were confirmed on an official government page, read directly on 28 September 2026; Ireland is taken from the Act itself:

- Austria: 10. Official source
- Cyprus: 8 (12 months plus 7 of the previous 10 years). Official source
- Denmark: 9. Official source

- Estonia: 8 (5 on a permanent basis). Official source
- Finland: 8 (5 with language skills). Official source
- France: 5. Official source
- Germany: 5 (three-year fast track abolished October 2025). Official source
- Italy: 10. Official source
- Latvia: 5. Official source
- Luxembourg: 5. Official source
- Netherlands: 5. Official source
- Portugal: 10 for non-EU nationals, 7 for EU and Portuguese-speaking countries. Official source
- Slovenia: 10. Official source
- Spain: 10. Official source
- Sweden: 8 (from 6 June 2026). Official source

Countries where permanent residence must come first, and how long it takes:

- Czechia: permanent residence after 5 years of continuous residence. Source (official page read directly).
- Latvia: permanent residence permit after 5 years with temporary permits; naturalisation needs 5 years with it. Source (official page read directly).
- Poland: EU long-term residence after 5 years of legal stay (study time counts half); naturalisation needs 3 years with it. Source (Office for Foreigners page; its text did not load for automated reading, so confirmed through search results quoting it).
- Slovakia: permanent residence after 5 years of uninterrupted legal residence; naturalisation needs 8 years of continuous permanent residence. Source (IOM Migration Information Centre, read directly for the 8-year rule; the 5-year rule confirmed through search results quoting its permanent-residence page).
- Bulgaria: permanent residence after 5 years of continuous residence; naturalisation needs 5 years with it (secondary sources; official sites did not state it in readable form).

In Estonia (8 years, of which 5 permanent), Croatia (8), Lithuania (10), Denmark (9) and Austria (10, of which 5 settled), permanent or long-term status is required but falls within the stated period, so nothing is added.

For Belgium (5), Croatia, Greece, Hungary (8), Lithuania, Malta (about 5: 4 of 6 years plus 12 months) and Romania (8), official websites refused automated access or did not state the period; the brief's figure was confirmed against current secondary sources and no change in force was found. Romania requires 8 years of legal domicile; whether time before long-term residence counts could not be confirmed from an official source, so it is shown at 8 with that caveat. Poland has bills for longer periods before its parliament, and Belgium's 2026 reform concerned loss of nationality, not the residence period.

Averages are the author's calculation: 218 ÷ 27 = 8.1 years. The figures are general minimums; many countries count only some kinds of permission or allow shorter periods for language skills, marriage or refugee status, so equal numbers of years are not always equally demanding.

Citizenship by nationality, and permits five years earlier

The nationality table is the Department's original spreadsheet for PQs 482–483. Yearly totals match the route table, apart from a few suppressed small values (at most 29 certificates a year). India's share is 6,298 ÷ 29,919 = 21.1% in 2025 and 1,026 ÷ 10,002 = 10.3% in 2016. Certificates rose by 29,919 − 9,766 = 20,153 between 2021 and 2025; India's rise of 6,298 − 746 = 5,552 is 27.5% of that. [6]

The permits-against-certificates chart compares first-time ("new") employment permits issued in 2015–2020 with certificates in 2021–2025, about the five years of residence the ordinary route requires. It covers the ten non-EU nationalities with the most certificates in 2021–2025; EU/EEA and UK citizens are excluded because they need no permit. Nationality names differ slightly between the two sources ("China" and "China (Including Hong Kong)"); they are matched by hand. The datasets cannot be linked person by person, and certificates include partners and children, so the chart compares nationalities, not individuals. [7]

Nurses and midwives

NMBI Table 2 classifies registrants by qualification location, not nationality. Its non-EU group includes the UK. The register covers public and private practice and some practitioners abroad; it is not an HSE staffing count. NMBI's definitions include assumptions about recent entrants.

Non-EU-educated shares: 42,432 ÷ 86,948 = 48.8% of practising registrants; 39,760 ÷ 79,194 = 50.2% of patient-facing registrants. [8]

Employment, education and public finances

The employment comparison uses citizenship, ages 20–64, and 2024 Eurostat figures reproduced in ESRI's June 2026 review, footnote 19. Education uses citizenship and ages 25–64. Welfare receipt uses birthplace and ages 15–65. These populations should not be treated as the same group or as a profile of citizenship applicants. [9] [10] [11]

The OECD table comes from the same ESRI review (printed pages 20–22), which reports OECD (2021) results for Ireland averaged over 2006–2018. Each row adds another layer of public spending to what is charged to each group: first individual benefits and services, then congestible public goods such as police, transport and water, then pure public goods such as defence and debt interest. The last row is the fiscal ratio for individual items. The period includes the post-2008 deficits and excludes recent surpluses. [9]

The fiscal table reproduces the JRC estimate discussed in section 3.1.2 of the ESRI review: annual income tax and social-insurance contributions less benefits per person, for 2015–2019. It excludes a full allocation of public-service costs. ESRI's broader conclusion draws on several studies with different accounting methods. [9] [12]

The family-benefit figures come from Table 4.1 of ESRI's welfare study, using CSO SILC data. The category includes universal Child Benefit. The survey covers private households, not the population in asylum accommodation. [11]

Earnings and care

The earnings figures describe employments active for at least 50 weeks in 2024, not household disposable income. (56,356 − 44,816) ÷ 44,816 × 100 = 25.8%. The Scheme has not selected the mean as a threshold. The comparison illustrates the consequences of choosing an income measure. [13] [14]

Women accounted for 181,592 of 299,128 unpaid carers in Census 2022: 60.7%, rounded to 61%. These are population counts, not citizenship-applicant counts. [15]

Test-centre planning estimate

Annual sittings = 41,511 applications × 2 tests × 1.20 = 99,626.4, rounded up. Annual centre capacity = seats × sessions per day × 200 operating days. Divide demand by capacity and round up to obtain the number of centres. Each centre is assumed to have one test room and each session to accommodate one test.

With 20 seats and two daily sessions, this gives 13 centres. Exempting 30% of applicants from both tests reduces that to nine. Removing retakes gives 11. Using only 80% of advertised seats raises the base case to 16.

This is a planning scenario, not an official forecast. The application total includes minors. Exemptions, recognised qualifications, combined tests and existing venues may reduce demand. Speaking assessments, accessible provision and regional coverage affect capacity. A launch backlog is excluded. [2]

Legal scope and transition

The General Scheme is a proposal. Regulations will determine the income amount, specified supports and testing details. No particular maternity, caring or disability payment is described here as already disqualifying. A language-test waiver does not itself waive an income condition. [14] [16]

The offence discussion identifies duties included in the proposed Schedule; an offence must still be established under the applicable law. General waiver powers must also be considered. "No time limit" describes the scheduled condition's wording, not a claim that no exception could ever apply.

The eight revocations include the two since April 2025. Earlier litigation disrupted the procedure, so a low count cannot by itself establish that wider powers are unnecessary. The 2024 IHREC statement concerns the earlier amendments; the Commission's October 2026 submission addresses the Scheme itself. The 2026 proposal removes consultation on procedural regulations, not consultation before individual revocation decisions. [17] [18] [19]

Children, residence examples and doctoral study

The January 2022 example assumes uninterrupted qualifying residence. The Scheme protects submitted applications from Head 9's new residence exclusions but does not provide comprehensive protection for everyone already resident. No claim is made that a further change in three to five years has been announced. [14]

The doctoral example assumes four years entirely on Stamp 2 followed by qualifying residence, with all other conditions met. Employed researchers may hold other permissions. Nine or twelve years is time to eligibility, excluding application processing. [20]

The child provisions change qualifying parental residence for future births. They do not raise the three-of-four-years test to eight years or remove other birth-citizenship and minor-naturalisation routes. The 6,949 certificates for minors do not measure how many children the proposal would affect. The published route table does not split minors by age or by legal route (section 15B or section 16), so it cannot show how many were 14 or older or how many needed the good-character waiver that Head 8 would remove. [14]

Download the evidence

Data tables and calculations

- additional-evidence.csv
- calculations.json
- employment_permits_annual_totals.csv
- employment_permits_by_nationality.csv
- employment_permits_by_type_occupation.csv
- employment_permits_by_type_sector.csv
- naturalisation_by_nationality.csv
- naturalisation_by_route.csv
- Source register (JSON)

Official source register

Department of Justice · General Scheme, 21 September 2026

View official source

Heads 4–10. Read from the official text archived in the supplied explainer; live publisher request returned HTTP 403. This is a legislative proposal, not enacted law.

Read the local source copy

Law Reform Commission · Irish Nationality and Citizenship Act 1956, revised

View official source

Sections 6A–6B, 15, 15A, 15B, 16, 16A and 19. Current-law baseline; consulted alongside the supplied official extracts.

Oireachtas · PQ 483, 22 January 2026

View official source

Tables 1–2: certificates issued, not applications or arrivals. The answer explicitly says prior immigration permissions are not available as a statistical breakdown. Live page returned HTTP 403; cached official answer and original attachment inspected.

Read the local source copy

Oireachtas · Original certificate tables (Word document)

View official source

Original attachment to PQs 482–483. Table 2 records certificates by application type. ‘S15 residency’ is the Department’s label for spouses and civil partners of Irish citizens; ‘Granted International Protection’ covers people with refugee status or subsidiary protection.

Read the local source copy

Oireachtas · Certificates by nationality, 2016–2025 (Excel)

View official source

Original attachment to PQs 482–483: certificates of naturalisation issued each year by nationality. Yearly totals match the route table except where the Department suppressed small values. Certificates issued, not applications or arrivals.

Read the local source copy

Oireachtas · PQ 2397, 7 September 2026

View official source

Applications 2021–2026, backlog at 31 August 2026, and absence of a statutory processing deadline. Cached official answer inspected; live publisher request returned HTTP 403.

Read the local source copy

Oireachtas · PQ 277, 17 September 2026

View official source

Median processing times 2021–2025. Eight months in 2024 and 2025 is neither a minimum nor a guarantee. Cached official answer inspected; live publisher request returned HTTP 403.

Read the local source copy

Department of Enterprise · Employment permit statistics

View official source

Annual counts from the supplied parsed departmental spreadsheets. Include renewals; not unique arrivals or future citizenship applicants.

Department of Enterprise · Employment permits by nationality, 2015–2026

View official source

Annual ‘permits by nationality’ spreadsheets. New permits exclude renewals, so they approximate first-time permits. Permit holders and later citizens cannot be linked person by person; the comparison shows matching nationalities, not the same individuals. EU/EEA and UK citizens need no permit.

CSO · Labour Force Survey, employment by citizenship (QLF59)

View official source

Author’s calculation; the CSO does not publish this percentage. It is the non-Irish share of the **net change in the number of people in employment**, not of “jobs created”.

- Q2 2021 to Q2 2026 (main base): employment rose by 457,100, of which non-Irish citizens 215,900 (47.2%).
- Q1 2021 to Q1 2026: 42.9%.
- From the 2021 annual average: about 52%.
- From a Q4 2021 base: about 65%.

Q1 and Q2 2021 were depressed by COVID-19 restrictions, which flatters growth measured from them. Non-Irish share of employment 16.6% (Q2 2021) and 21.5% (Q2 2026). Naturalised migrants are counted as Irish citizens, so these figures understate migrants’ share.

Oireachtas · Employment permits by type and sector (Excel)

View official source

2024 sector totals calculated across permit types in the supplied parsed attachment. Total 39,398 differs by eight from the departmental annual series (39,390); use this attachment's denominator throughout.

Oireachtas · PQ 56, 26 March 2025

View official source

2024 Critical Skills permits by occupation, from the supplied parsed supporting document: nurses 5,031; programmers and software development professionals 2,247.

Department of Enterprise · Occupations lists and reviews

View official source

Official explanation of how eligible occupations are selected and reviewed; checked through live web research.

Department of Enterprise · Permit changes for homes, health and transport, 28 May 2026

View official source

Concrete example of changing occupation eligibility and quotas to respond to labour shortages; checked through live web research.

CSO · Annual earnings 2024, Table 7.1

View official source

Mean €56,356; median €44,816. Employments active for fewer than 50 weeks excluded. Chosen as a matched-year statistical illustration, not a proposed legal threshold; checked live.

CSO · Educational Attainment 2024, Table 3.4

View official source

Third-level attainment among 25–64-year-olds, Q2 2024: non-Irish 67%, Irish 53%. Population evidence, not citizenship-applicant evidence; checked live.

ESRI · Monitoring Report on Integration 2024, Table A / Figure 2.1

View official source

Government-funded primary analysis of official CSO Labour Force Survey microdata. Q1 2024, ages 15–64: foreign-born employment 76.8%, unemployment 5.8%; Irish-born 72.7%, 3.5%. The employment denominator is working-age population; unemployment uses the labour force. PDF

inspected live. Table A also gives the citizenship indicators: annual acquisition rate for non-EEA nationals 4.0%; 29.7% of non-EEA migrants who arrived since 2005 had acquired Irish citizenship.

CSO · Census 2022, Profile 4: Carers

View official source

299,128 unpaid carers; 61% female. All residents, not applicant-specific; checked live.

Government · Global Citizens 2030 talent and innovation strategy

View official source

Strategy launched 15 January 2024. Innovate for Ireland seeks to attract high-calibre PhD students. Policy intent, not a measured impact of citizenship rules; checked through live web research.

Immigration Service Delivery · Immigration permission stamps

View official source

Current distinctions between Stamp 2 study permission and reckonable permissions, including Stamp 1G. Eligibility depends on the actual permission; checked through live web research.

European Parliamentary Research Service · Acquisition and loss of citizenship in EU Member States, 2025, Figure 2

View official source

Figure 2, page 4: minimum residence for ordinary naturalisation by country (GLOBALCIT 2022 with the author's 2025 updates; EMN 2024). The chart is an image; values were read from it: 10 years AT, IT, LT, SI, ES; 9 DK; 8 HR, CY, EE, FI, HU, RO, SK; 7 EL; 5 BE, BG, CZ, FR, DE, IE, LV, LU, MT, NL, PT, SE; 3 PL; EU average 6.9. The text states the range of 3 to 10 years. Countries count different kinds of residence, so equal numbers of years are not always equally demanding. Updated in September 2026 for Sweden (8 years from 6 June 2026) and Portugal (10 years for non-EU nationals from 19 May 2026), and recalculated to include the time needed to obtain permanent residence where a country requires it; see 'EU residence requirements' on the sources page. The 'about eight years' average (218 ÷ 27 = 8.1) is the author's calculation.

Read the local source copy

Swedish Migration Agency · New rules for Swedish citizenship from 6 June 2026

View official source

"From 6 June, you must as a general rule have lived in Sweden for at least eight years (previously five years)." The Riksdag approved the change on 29 April 2026. Checked live on 28 September 2026.

The Dutch requirement was also rechecked on the IND website: still at least five consecutive years.

Diário da República · Organic Law 1/2026 amending the Nationality Law, 18 May 2026

View official source

Article 6(1)(b): legal residence of “at least seven years” for nationals of Portuguese-speaking countries and EU citizens, “or 10 years, in the case of nationals of other countries”. In force the day after publication (19 May 2026); applications already filed continue under the previous rules. Official gazette PDF read on 28 September 2026.

Read the local source copy

Department of Justice · Press release on priority drafting of the Bill, September 2026

View official source

Notes to Editors: “Several countries impose residence periods of 7 to 10 years, including Austria, Italy, Lithuania, Slovenia, Spain and Switzerland.” Quotation taken from research notes made at publication; the live page refused automated access (HTTP 403) when rechecked on 28 September 2026.

Citizens Information · The Schengen Area

View official source

“Ireland is not part of the Schengen Area.” “If you are a non-EEA citizen and you currently live in Ireland, you may need a Schengen visa to travel to the Schengen Area, even if you have a valid Irish Residence Permit (IRP).” Checked live on 28 September 2026.

European Commission · EU Visa Strategy, COM(2026) 43, 29 January 2026

View official source

Section 3, printed page 13: funding should strengthen processing capacity “in locations where applicants face long waiting times for Schengen visa appointments”. Page 10 also records concerns from universities and employers about “difficulties in booking appointments” for long-stay visas.

Read the local source copy

Oireachtas · PQ 883, 16 September 2026

View official source

Eight revocations over the preceding ten years, two since 7 April 2025; seven fraud-related and one under loyalty/residence grounds. Also confirms reviews of terrorism and serious crime. Cached official answer inspected.

Read the local source copy

Law Reform Commission · Section 19, revised

View official source

Existing substantive grounds and inquiry safeguards; read alongside supplied current-law extract.

IHREC · Revocation changes need proper scrutiny, 16 July 2024

View official source

Official commission statement about the 2024 amendments, not an opinion on the 2026 Scheme. Identifies concerns about initiation thresholds, inquiry independence and restrictions concerning national-security material. Replaces the earlier citation relying on a search-index extract. For the Commission's view on the 2026 Scheme, see the October 2026 submission.

IHREC · Submission on the General Scheme, October 2026

View official source

Pre-legislative scrutiny submission on the 2026 General Scheme (file dated 9 October 2026). PDF pages 18 (Head 8: good character for minors over 14) and 19–23 (Head 10: the new ground, reasons in national-security cases, legal certainty, Damache, AP and the Committee of Inquiry); pages 9–11 set out the ECHR and EU-law standards. Original PDF downloaded and inspected on 26 October 2026. The submission quotes the Head 10 explanatory note as describing a "streamlined procedural track used to fast-track executive action"; that wording does not appear in the archived Scheme text used here, so the site quotes the archived wording instead. The submission gives the Damache citation as both [2021] IESC 6 and [2020] IESC 63; the site uses [2020] IESC 63.

Read the local source copy

Bar of Ireland · Submission on the General Scheme, October 2026

View official source

Submission of the Council of The Bar of Ireland to the Joint Committee on Justice, Home Affairs and Migration. PDF page numbers are one higher than the printed ones. PDF pages 5–9 (civics, language, Northern Ireland, offences, revocation), 9–12 (Head 6 and de facto partners), 12 (Head 8), 13–14 (Head 9 and section 6B(5)) and 15–17 (proportionality, transition, ministerial discretion, all-island character). The publisher's page blocks automated access; the PDF was supplied by the project owner and inspected on 26 October 2026. Its account of sections 6B(5), 15(1)(c) and 15A(1) was checked against the revised Act. Three statements are not used: that more than half of EU member states require five years (the site's own country check finds seven of 27, or ten of 27 on the unadjusted 2026 figures); that the Scheme "replaces" the good-character test (Head 8 keeps it and

makes it impossible to waive); and that Head 7 sets no criteria for the income figure (section 15F(2) lists them, ending with “such other matters as the Minister considers appropriate”).

Read the local source copy

NMBI · State of the Register 2025, Table 2 (p. 10)

View official source

Snapshot at 1 June 2025. Counts nurses and midwives by country of qualification, not citizenship. The practising category includes registrants abroad and assumptions about new registrants; it is not an HSE headcount. Non-EU includes the UK. Original PDF downloaded and inspected.

Read the local source copy

NMBI · State of the Register 2024, Table 5

View official source

First-time registrants, 1 June 2023 to 31 May 2024: 5,426 qualified outside the EU, 1,569 in Ireland, 125 in other EU countries (7,120 in total). Up from 3,021 non-EU registrants in 2022.

Read the local source copy

Medical Council · Medical Workforce Intelligence Report 2025

View official source

Published 2 September 2026. Table 1 (p. 18): 22,257 clinically active doctors by country of basic medical qualification: Ireland 56.6%, EU/UK 13.9%, international 29.5% (up from 27.8% in 2024 and 23.3% in 2022). Outside Ireland: 13.9% + 29.5% = 43.4%. Qualification location, not nationality.

Read the local source copy

ESRI · Literature review on the fiscal impacts of immigration, June 2026

View official source

Chapter 3, pp. 22 and 29; Chapter 4. Employment comparison reproduces Eurostat 2024, ages 20–64, by citizenship. Fiscal estimates are JRC 2020 results for 2015–2019 reported in the review: income taxes and social insurance minus annual benefits per person. They are not a comprehensive public-service cost balance or a 2026 forecast. OECD (2021) estimates for Ireland, averaged over 2006–2018, are reported on printed pages 20–22: individual taxes less benefits and services, then adding congestible and pure public goods, and the fiscal ratio.

Read the local source copy

ESRI · Fiscal impact and welfare receipt, 10 June 2026

View official source

Publisher's summary of two reports funded by the Department of Justice. Direct quotation on the Ireland page is 17 words. Conclusions describe migrant populations, not individual citizenship applicants.

ESRI · Social transfers utilisation among migrants and Irish-born, Table 4.1

View official source

June 2026, Table 4.1 and discussion, printed p. 11. CSO SILC, ages 15–65. In 2024 family-payment receipt was 58% for immigrants and 47% for Irish-born people. Includes universal Child Benefit. Main analysis concerns private households; it is not a measure of asylum-centre residents.

Read the local source copy

Immigration Service Delivery · Joining-family requirements

View official source

Official rules on eligible sponsors, qualifying family relationships, financial requirements and permission. Used to establish that family residence is regulated, not to calculate applicant proportions.

Irish Statute Book · Employment Permits Act 2024

View official source

Statutory basis for employment permits and exemptions. Employment permission does not itself substitute for immigration permission.

Law Reform Commission · Immigration Act 2004, section 9

View official source

Sections 9(2)(b)–(d) and 9(8): updating registration information; address change within 48 hours if not previously notified; absence from residence exceeding one month; offence provision. Duties apply to persons within the section, subject to statutory exclusions.

Law Reform Commission · Immigration Act 2004, section 12

View official source

Production on a lawful demand for the purpose of establishing compliance with section 5. Section 12(2)(b) provides a reasonable-cause defence. The original provision was replaced in 2011; the

revised text is used here.

Courts Service · Hussain v Minister for Justice [2011] IEHC 171

View official source

Hogan J., 13 April 2011, paragraphs 15 and 22–26. Reasonable civic standards and fair procedures; serious wrongdoing can be considered even without a conviction. The phrase “good character is not perfection” is a summary, not a quotation.

Read the local source copy

Oireachtas · PQ 894, 16 September 2026

View official source

Grouped answer by the Minister of State confirms test standards, methods, exemptions, civics content and self-sufficiency details were not settled. States that the new residence periods are “intended to apply from enactment of the new Bill”; the later Scheme uses commencement orders, so enactment and commencement are distinguished. Read from the cached official parliamentary answer.

Read the local source copy

International Protection Act 2015

View official source

Statutory framework for international-protection applications and decisions. Publisher access returned HTTP 403 during this review; cited for the framework, not a claim that later amendments do not apply.

Sources

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2. Oireachtas · PQ 2397, 7 September 2026 (https://www.oireachtas.ie/en/debates/question/2026-09-07/2397/) Research note
3. Oireachtas · PQ 277, 17 September 2026 (https://www.oireachtas.ie/en/debates/question/2026-09-17/277/) Research note
4. Oireachtas · Employment permits by type and sector (Excel) (https://data.oireachtas.ie/ie/oireachtas/debates/questions/supportingDocumentation/2025-05-20_pq381-20-05-25_en.xlsx)

Research note

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6. Oireachtas · Certificates by nationality, 2016–2025 (Excel) (https://data.oireachtas.ie/ie/oireachtas/debates/questions/supportingDocumentation/2026-01-22_pq-482-483b-22-01-2026_en.xlsx) Research note
7. Department of Enterprise · Employment permits by nationality, 2015–2026 (https://enterprise.gov.ie/en/what-we-do/workplace-and-skills/employment-permits/statistics/) Research note
8. NMBI · State of the Register 2025, Table 2 (p. 10) (https://www.nmbi.ie/NMBI/media/NMBI/NMBI-State-of-The-Register-2025.pdf?ext=.pdf#page=12) Research note
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13. CSO · Annual earnings 2024, Table 7.1 (https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-eaads/earningsanalysisusingadministrativedatasources2024/annualearnings/) Research note
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15. CSO · Census 2022, Profile 4: Carers (https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-cpp4/censusofpopulation2022profile4-disabilityhealthandcarers/carers/) Research note
16. Oireachtas · PQ 894, 16 September 2026 (https://www.oireachtas.ie/en/debates/question/2026-09-16/894/) Research note
17. Oireachtas · PQ 883, 16 September 2026 (https://www.oireachtas.ie/en/debates/question/2026-09-16/883/) Research note
18. IHREC · Revocation changes need proper scrutiny, 16 July 2024 (https://www.ihrec.ie/commission-urges-minister-to-delay-plans-to-amend-legislation-to-revoke-irish-citizenship-without-proper-scrutiny/) Research note
19. Law Reform Commission · Section 19, revised (https://revisedacts.lawreform.ie/eli/1956/act/26/section/19/revised/en/html) Research note
20. Immigration Service Delivery · Immigration permission stamps (https://www.irishimmigration.ie/registering-your-immigration-permission/information-on-registering/immigration-permission-stamps/) Research note